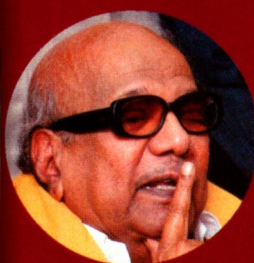


OUR

It's a circus out there as political parties outdo each other to bid for the Bharat Ratna and reduce the country's highest civilian honour to a national shame



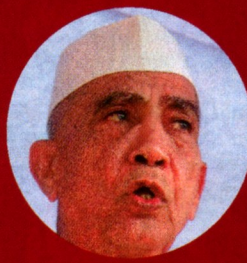
M. KARUNANIDHI
DMK wants one for its leader. Says its request is three years old and should take precedence over Advani's.



JAGJIVAN RAM
It was his daughter Meira Kumar's idea, but Ram Vilas Paswan jumped on to the bandwagon to counter Mayawati.



BIJU PATNAIK
BJD has been asking for one ever since 1997. The move could queer the pitch for BJP's demand for Vajpayee.



CHARAN SINGH
Proposed by his son Ajit Singh, who claims it was his late father who kept UP free of Naxalites. Few buy this.



MULAYAM SINGH
SP's Assam unit showed the first signs of its existence by demanding a Bharat Ratna for its boss.

While Congress prime ministers Indira Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru were awarded the Ratna when they were still in office, and Rajiv Gandhi was given one posthumously by a Congress government, BJP points out that Vajpayee did not give one to himself when NDA was in power. A Padma Vibhushan awardee, he was conferred this honour by the Narasimha Rao Government in 1992. "A non-Gandhi Congressman," points out a BJP leader.

Controversy, however, is not new to the Bharat Ratna. There have been cases in the past where allegations of political cronyism have been levied such as when AIADMK founder M.G. Ramachandran was given one (posthumously) in 1988 before even B.R. Ambedkar or Sardar Patel got theirs. In 1991, Rajiv was awarded his along with Patel, who had to wait 41 years after his death for this recognition (one view is that Rajiv was given the award as part of the sympathy quota after his assassination). However, the other Gandhi—Mahatma Gandhi is still to be decorated with the country's highest honour.

The Bharat Ratna was constituted in 1954, six years after Mahatma

Gandhi's death, and the debate is still on as to whether the Mahatma is above such awards. Given the level of petty politicking that is going on, that argument has some merit. Points out constitutional expert, Rajiv Dhawan, "Article 18 of the Constitution states that there should be no titles. Yet, everyone is treating this like a knighthood. This is an honour to be given to distinguished persons. There are no political reservations for the Ratna."

CROWNED JEWELS

Of the 40 Ratna recipients, more than half are politicians

GOVIND BALLABH PANT: 1955

PURUSHOTTAM DAS TANDON: 1961

ZAKIR HUSSAIN: 1963

V.V. GIRI: 1975

M.G. RAMACHANDRAN: 1988

MORARJI DESAI: 1991

RAJIV GANDHI: 1991

ARUNA ASAF ALI: 1997

GULZARI LAL NANDA: 1997

GOPINATH BORDOLOI: 1999

For the past seven years, no Bharat Ratnas have been awarded. The last one was in 2001 for Lata Mangeshkar and Ustad Bismillah Khan. At that time, NDA wanted to honour Veer Savarkar too and had even discussed it with the President. "The then president K.R. Narayanan was against it and Vajpayee did not push him," recalls a former PMO official. In his recent letter to the prime minister, Advani refers to Savarkar's case, when he says some people who deserved the honour posthumously were not even considered.

Savarkar was not the only name considered by the NDA. At least 10 Congress and BJP chief ministers, sundry cabinet ministers had made a strong case for Dhirubhai Ambani. The opposition to this was led by Advani who was then deputy prime minister. Later, while releasing a stamp with Ambani's portrait, then cabinet minister, late Pramod Mahajan wondered if "naachnewale aur gaanewale (singers and dancers) can be given Bharat Ratnas, why not Ambani?" Maybe that's why today's politicians are making such a song-and-dance about this less-than-honourable-exercise. ■